Ordinary Differential Equations

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1 Introduction

An ordinary differential equation (ODE) is an equation involving an unknown function and its ordinary derivatives with respect to **a single independent variable**. The goal of solving an ODE is to find a function that satisfies the given equation.

For example, consider

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}t} = \cos(t),$$

we know

$$x(t) = \sin(t) + C,$$

where C is an arbitrary constant. This example illustrates an important point that knowing the derivative of a function does not necessarily determine the function **uniquely**. Now, suppose we given the initial condition

$$x(0) = 2.$$

Substituting $t = 0$ into the general solution gives

$$x(0) = \sin(0) + C = C.$$

Since $x(0) = 2$, we obtain $C = 2$. Therefore, the unique solution satisfying both the ODE and the initial condition is

$$x(t) = \sin(t) + 2.$$

In general, solving an ODE can be much more complicated than finding an antiderivative. Nevertheless, integration provides a fundamental connection between a differential equation and its solution.

More generally, we can specify a condition of the form

$$x(t_0) = x_0,$$

where t_0 is a given initial point and x_0 is the corresponding value of the unknown function. The is called an **initial condition**. This leads naturally to the concept of an **initial value problem (IVP)**, in which a differential equation is accompanied by a prescribed value of the unknown function at an initial point.

2 Initial Value Problem

The initial value problem for a first-order ordinary differential equation

$$\begin{cases} y' = f(t, y(t)), & t \in [a, b] \\ y(a) = y_a \end{cases}$$

For example, **the logistic equation** $y' = ay(1 - y)$.
In real model, y usually represents the population.

$$\text{I.V.P} \quad \begin{cases} y' = ay(1 - y), & t \in [0, T] \\ y(0) = y_0 \end{cases} \qquad \longrightarrow \qquad y(t) = 1 - \frac{1}{1 + \frac{y_0}{1-y_0} e^{at}}, \text{ if } y_0 \neq 1.$$

A wide majority of interesting D.E. have no closed-form solution. A much more common scenario is a D.E. with no explicit solution formula. For example,

$$\begin{cases} y' = 3e^{\frac{t^2}{2}} - t^2 - 2 \\ y(0) = 1 \end{cases}$$

When an ordinary differential equation (ODE) has no closed-form solution, we cannot express its solution using standard analytical formulas. In such cases, we must turn to **numerical methods** to approximate the solution at discrete points.

3 Euler's Method

Euler's method uses the derivative at the current point to estimate the solution at the next point. Recall the definition of a derivative

$$y'(t) = \lim_{h \to 0} \frac{y(t + h) - y(t)}{h}.$$

For a sufficiently small step size h, we approximate the derivative by a forward difference

$$y'(t) \approx \frac{y(t + h) - y(t)}{h}.$$

Rearranging gives

$$y(t + h) \approx y(t) + hy'(t).$$

Since $y'(t) = f(t, y(t))$, we obtain Euler's formula

$$y_{n+1} = y_n + hf(t_n, y_n),$$

3.1 Lipschitz constant

Definition: A function $f(t, y)$ satisfies the Lipschitz condition in the variable y on the rectangles $S = [a, b] \times [\alpha, \beta]$ if there exists a constant L (called the **Lipschitz constant**) such that

$$|f(t, y_1) - f(t, y_2)| \leq L|y_1 - y_2| \quad \text{for all } (t, y_1), (t, y_2) \text{ in } S.$$

Note: A useful condition is that if the partial derivative $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}$ exists and is bounded on a suitable region, then f is Lipschitz continuous in y there. According to Mean value theorem

$$\frac{f(t, y_1) - f(t, y_2)}{y_1 - y_2} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t, c)$$

where c is between y_1 and y_2. Then L can be taken as the maximum of $|\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t, c)|$ on S.

Example 1: A function that satisfies the condition. Consider

$$f(t, y) = 2y.$$

Then

$$|f(t, y_1) - f(t, y_2)| = 2|y_1 - y_2|.$$

Therefore, f is **globally** Lipschitz continuous in y, with $L = 2$.

Example 2: A function that is **locally** Lipschitz. Consider

$$f(t, y) = y^2.$$

We have

$$|y_1^2 - y_2^2| = |y_1 - y_2||y_1 + y_2|.$$

If $|y_1|$, $|y_2| \leq M$, then

$$|y_1^2 - y_2^2| \leq 2M|y_1 - y_2|.$$

Thus, f is Lipschitz continuous on every bounded interval in y, and **locally** Lipschitz on the entire real line.

Example 3: A continuous function that is not locally Lipschitz. Consider

$$f(t, y) = \sqrt{|y|}.$$

At $y = 0$, compare $y_1 = 0$ and $y_2 = y > 0$. The Lipschitz condition would require

$$\sqrt{y} \leq Ly,$$

or equivalently,

$$\frac{1}{\sqrt{y}} \leq L.$$

As y approaches zero, the left-hand side becomes unbounded. No finite L can satisfy the condition in a neighborhood of zero. So f is continuous but not locally Lipschitz at $y = 0$.

3.2 Existence and Uniqueness Theorem (E.U.T)

Definition: Assume that $f(t,y)$ is Lipschitz in the variable y on $[a,b]\times[\alpha,\beta]$ and $y_a \in (\alpha,\beta)$. Then $\exists c \in (a,b)$ such that I.V.P. $\begin{cases} y' = f(t,y) \\ y(a) = y_a \end{cases}$ has exactly one solution $y(t)$ for $t \in [a,c]$. Moreover, if f is Lipschitz on $[a,b]\times(-\infty,\infty)$, then there exists a unique solution on $[a,b]$.

Example 1: Consider $\begin{cases} y' = y^2 \\ y(0) = 1 \end{cases}$.

Since $f(t,y) = y^2$ we know $\frac{\partial f}{\partial y} = 2y$. $L = \max|2y| = 20$ on $[0,2]\times[-10,10]$. E.U.T. guarantees $y(t)$ uniquely exists on $[0,c]$, $c>0$ but not guarantees on the entire $[0,2]$.

In fact, $y(t) = \frac{1}{1-t}$. So, the solution exists on $[0,c]$ for any $0<c<1$.

Note: Since$\frac{dy}{y^2} = dt$, we obtain $-\frac{1}{y} = t + C$. Substituting the initial condition, so $C = -1$. Thus, $-\frac{1}{y} = t-1$ which can be rewritten $y = \frac{1}{1-t}$.

Example 2: Consider $\begin{cases} y' = y^2 \\ y(0) = y_0 \end{cases}$.

From previous example we know that $f(t,y) = y^2$ is Lipschitz continuous on $[-a,a]$ for all $a>0$.

Case 1: $y_0 \equiv 0$. Then $y(t) = 0$ is a solution.

Case 2: $y_0 \neq 0$. Then $y(t) = \frac{1}{y_0^{-1} - t}$.

$$\begin{cases} \text{If } y_0 > 0, \text{ then } y(t) = \frac{1}{y_0^{-1}-t} \text{ for } t \in (-\infty, \frac{1}{y_0}) \\ \text{If } y_0 < 0, \text{ then } y(t) = \frac{1}{y_0^{-1}-t} \text{ for } t \in (\frac{1}{y_0}, \infty) \end{cases}$$

Example 3: Consider $\begin{cases} y' = \begin{cases} \sqrt{y}, y \geq 0 \\ 0, y \leq 0 \end{cases} \\ y(0) = 0 \end{cases}$.

Case 1: $y(t) = \begin{cases} \frac{(t-c)^2}{4}, t \geq c \\ 0, t \leq c \end{cases}$ is a solution for any $c \geq 0$.

Case 2: $y(t) \equiv 0$ is also a solution.

Thus, in this example, there are infinitely many solutions.

Note: $\frac{dy}{\sqrt{y}} = dt$. We can write $\int y^{-1/2} dy = \int 1 dt$. So, $2\sqrt{y} = t + C$. We have $y = \frac{(t+C)^2}{4}$. Set $C = -c$, we have $y = \frac{(t-c)^2}{4}$

3.3 Continuous dependence of solutions on initial conditions

Definition: Assume that $f(t,y)$ is Lipschitz in variable y on $S=[a,b]\times[\alpha,\beta]$. If $y(t)$ and $z(t)$ are solutions of $\begin{cases} y'=f(t,y) \\ y(a)=y_a \end{cases}$ and $\begin{cases} z'=f(t,z) \\ z(a)=z_a \end{cases}$, respectively, then

$$|y(t)-z(t)| \le e^{L(t-a)}|y(a)-z(a)|.$$

Proof: By the uniqueness of solution, $y(a)=z(a)$ implies $y(t)=z(t)$. We may assume $y(a)\neq z(a)$. In this case, the uniqueness implies $y(t)\neq z(t), \forall t$.
Define $u(t)=y(t)-z(t)$, then $u(t)>0$ or $u(t)<0$. Because $|y(t)-z(t)|$ only depends on $|u|$, we may assume $u>0$.

$$u'(t)=y'(t)-z'(t)=f(t,y(t))-f(t,z(t))$$

The Lipschitz condition implies

$$u' \le |u'| = |f(t,y(t)-f(t,z(t))| \le L|y(t)-z(t)| = L|u(t)| = Lu(t),$$

which means

$$(\ln u)' = \frac{u'}{u} \le L.$$

By the mean value theorem, $\frac{\ln u(t)-\ln u(a)}{t-a} \le L$ which simplifies to $\ln\frac{u(t)}{u(a)} \le L(t-a)$. Thus, $u(t)\le u(a)e^{L(t-a)}$.

3.4 Global error

Theorem: Assume $f(t,y)$ has a Lipschitz constant L for the variable y and y_i is the solution of IVP $\begin{cases} y'=f(t,y) \\ y(a)=y_a \end{cases}$ $a\le t\le b$ at t_i, w_i is the one-step ODE solver withe the local truncation error $e_i \le ch^{k+1}$. Then for $a\le t_i\le b$, the solver has global truncation error

$$g_i = |w_i-y_i| \le \frac{c}{L}h^k(e^{L(t_i-a)}-1).$$

Proof: Set $g_0=|w_0-y_0|=|y_a-y_a|=0$ and $g_1=e_1=|w_1-y_1|$.
Let $z(t)$ be the solution of $\begin{cases} y'=f(t,y) \\ y(t_1)=w_1 \end{cases}$, $t\in[t_1,t_2]$ and then $e_2=|w_2-z(t_2)|$.
By initial value continuous theorem, we have $|z(t_2)-y_2|\le e^{Lh}|w_1-y_1|$. Thus

$$\begin{aligned} g_2 &= |w_2-y_2| \\ &= |w_2-z(t_2)+z(t_2)-y_2| \\ &\le |w_2-z(t_2)|+|z(t_2)-y_2| \\ &\le e_2+e^{Lh}g_1 \\ &= e_2+e^{Lh}e_1. \end{aligned}$$

Similarly,

$$\begin{aligned} g_3 &= |w_3 - y_3| \le e_3 + e^{Lh} g_2 \le e_3 + e^{Lh} e_2 + e^{2Lh} e_1. \\ &\vdots \\ g_i &= |w_i - y_i| \le e_i + e^{Lh} e_{i-1} + e^{2Lh} e_{i-2} + \cdots + e^{(n-1)Lh} e_1. \end{aligned}$$

Assume the local truncation error $e_i \le c \cdot h^{k+1}$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} g_i &\le ch^{k+1}[1 + e^{Lh} + \cdots + e^{(i+1)Lh}] \\ &= ch^{k+1} \frac{e^{iLh-1}}{e^{Lh} - 1} \\ &\le ch^{k+1} \frac{e^{L(t_i - a)-1}}{Lh} \\ &= \frac{c}{L} h^k (e^{L(t_i-a)-1}). \end{aligned}$$

Note:
$i \cdot h = (t_i - a)$
$1 + x \le e^x$ which means $1 + (Lh) \le e^{Lh}$. Then $Lh \le e^{Lh} - 1$.

3.5 Euler's Method Error

Assume $y \in \mathbb{C}^2$ the exact solution at $t_{i+1} = t_i + h$ is

$$y(t_i + h) = y(t_i) + h \cdot y'(t_i) + \frac{h^2}{2} y''(c), t_i \le c \le t_{i+1}.$$

Assume $y(t_i) = w_i$ and $y'(t_i) = f(t_i, w_i)$. Then

$$y(t_{i+1}) = w_i + h \cdot f(t_i, w_i) + \frac{h^2}{2} y''(c).$$

Meanwhile, Euler's method says $w_{i+1} = w_i + h \cdot f(t_i, w_i)$ which means

$$e_{i+1} = |w_{i+1} - y(t_{i+1})| = \frac{h^2}{2} |y''(c)| \le \frac{M}{2} h^2, \text{ where } M \equiv \max_{[t_i, t_{i+1}]} y''(x).$$

Corollary: Assume $f(t, y)$ has a Lipshitz constant L in variably y. The global truncation error from Euler's method satisfies

$$|w_i - y_i| \le \frac{Mh}{2L} (e^{L(t_i - a)-1}), M = \max_{t \in [a,b]} y''(t).$$

4 The Explicit Trapezoid Method (Heun Method)

Consider an initial value problem

$$\begin{cases} y' = f(t, y(t)) \\ y(t_0) = y_0 \end{cases}.$$

Euler's method approximates the solution using the slope at the beginning of each time step,

$$y_{n+1} = y_n + hf(t_n, y_n).$$

The weakness is that it uses only one slope. The Explicit Trapezoidal Method improves this by using both the slope at the beginning and an estimated slope at the end of the step.

The key idea is to approximate the integral of the derivative over one time step using the area of a trapezoid. Since $y' = f(t, y)$, integrating from t_n to t_{n+1} gives,

$$y(t_{n+1}) = y_n + \int_{t_n}^{t_{n+1}} f(t, y(t))dt.$$

We approximate this integral using the average of the two endpoint slopes multiplied by the step size.

4.1 Deriving the formula

For an initial value problem $y' = f(t, y)$ with $y(t_0) = y_0$, each time step h proceeds as follows:

Predictor Step (Euler): Calculate an intermediate approximation w^*_{i+1}.

$$w^*_{i+1} = w_i + hf(t, w_i).$$

Corrector Step (Trapezoidal Average): Use the average of the slope at the starting point and the slope evaluated at the predicted endpoint to obtain the corrected value.

$$w_{i+1} = w_i + \frac{h}{2}[f(t_i, w_i) + f(t_{i+1}, w_{i+1})].$$

Thus, we can write

$$\begin{cases} w_0 = y_0 \\ w_{i+1} = w_i + \frac{h}{2}[f(t_i, w_i) + f(t_i + h, w_i + h \cdot f(t_i, w_i))] \end{cases}$$

Example: Consider the initial value problem

$$y' = y + t, \qquad y(0) = 1$$

with step size $h = 0.1$. The exact solution is $y = 2e^t - t - 1$

Step1 - Predictor (Euler step) : $1 + (0.1) * (1 + 0) = 1.1$.

Step2 - Trapezoidal correction : $1 + (0.1/2) * (1 + (1.1 + 0.1)) = 1.11$.

The numerical approximation is 1.11 and exact value is $(2e^{0.1} - 0.1 - 1) \approx 1.110341836$.
So absolute error ≈ 0.000341836.

In the special case $y' = f(t)$, using the trapezoid rule to approximate $\int_{t_i}^{t_i+h} f(t)dt$ is

$$\frac{h}{2}[f(t_i) + f(t_i + h)].$$

Thus, the trapezoid method in the case is $w_{i+1} = w_i + \frac{h}{2}[f(t_i) + f(t_i + h)]$.
We do not need an Euler predictor because the derivative depends only on time and can be evaluated directly at both endpoints of the time interval.

For example: Consider the initial value problem $y' = 3t^2, y(0) = 1$, with step size $h = 0.1$.

Using the formula directly

$$w_1 = 1 + \frac{0.1}{2}[0 + 3 \cdot 0.1^2] = 1.0015.$$

The exact solution is $y(t) = t^3 + 1$, so the exact value at $t = 0.1$ is 1.001. Thus, the error is 0.0005. This numerical result is close to the exact solution.

4.2 Trapezoid Method Error

Assume $y \in \mathbf{C}^3$ and $y' = f(t, y)$ then

$$y'' = \frac{\partial f}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}y' = \frac{\partial f}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}f(t, y).$$

We have $y_{i+1} = y_i + hy'(t_i) + \frac{h^2}{2}y''(t_i) + \frac{h^3}{6}y'''(\xi_i)$, where $t_i < \xi_i < t_{i+1}$. Then, we can write

$$y_{i+1} = y_i + hy'(t_i) + \frac{h^2}{2}\left[\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_i, y_i) + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_i, y_i)f(t_i, y_i)\right] + \frac{h^3}{6}y'''(\xi_i) \qquad -(*)$$

Using 2-dimensional Taylor expansion,

$$f(t_i + h, y_i + hf(t_i, y_i)) = f(t_i, y_i) + h\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_i, y_i) + hf(t_i, y_i)\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_i, y_i) + O(h^2).$$

Thus the trapezoid method can be written

$$\begin{aligned} w_{i+1} &= y_i + \frac{h}{2}[f(t_i, y_i) + f(t_i + h, y_i + hf(t_i, y_i))] \\ &= y_i + \frac{h}{2}f(t_i, y_i) + \frac{h}{2}[f(t_i, y_i) + h\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_i, y_i) + hf(t_i, y_i)\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_i, y_i) + O(h^2)] \\ &= y_i + hf(t_i, y_i) + \frac{h^2}{2}[\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_i, y_i) + f(t_i, y_i)\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_i, y_i)] + O(h^3) \qquad -(**) \end{aligned}$$

Let (*)-(**), which means $y_{i+1} - w_{i+1} = O(h^3)$.

Therefore, its one-step local truncation error is of order 3. Furthermore, by the theorem we mentioned global error in section 3.4, the global error of trapezoid method is of order 2.

4.3 Midpoint Method

Evaluates the slope at the estimated midpoint and uses it for the entire step.

$$\begin{cases} w_0 = y_0 \\ w_{i+1} = w_i + hf(t_i + \frac{h}{2}, w_i + \frac{h}{2}f(t_i, w_i)) \end{cases}$$

Comparison with the Explicit Trapezoidal Method, which estimates the slope at the predicted endpoint, then averages it with the initial slope.

$$\begin{cases} w_0 = y_0 \\ w_{i+1} = w_i + \frac{h}{2}f(t_i, w_i) + \frac{h}{2}[f(t_i + h, w_i + hf(t_i, w_i))] \end{cases}$$

4.4 Midpoint Method Error

$$\begin{aligned} y_{i+1} &= y_i + hf(t_i, y_i) + \frac{h^2}{2}\left[\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_i, y_i) + \frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_i, y_i)f(t_i, y_i)\right] + \frac{h^3}{6}y'''(\xi_i) - (*) \\ w_i &= y_i + h\left[f(t_i + \frac{h}{2}, y_i + \frac{h}{2}f(t_i, y_i))\right] \\ &= y_i + h\left[f(t_i, y_i) + \frac{h}{2}\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_i, y_i) + \frac{h}{2}f(t_i, y_i)\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_i, y_i) + O(h^2)\right] - (**) \end{aligned}$$

Let (*)-(**), we have $y_{i+1} - w_{i+1} = O(h^3)$.

Therefore, its one-step local truncation error is of order 3. Furthermore, by the theorem we mentioned global error in section 3.4, the global error of midpoint method is of order 2. We got the same conclusion as Trapezoid method.

5 Runge-Kutta Method

A Appendix

A.1 Taylor's Theorem in two variables

$$f(t,y) = P_n(t,y) + R_n(t,y)$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} P_n(t,y) = f(t_0,y_0) &+ \left[(t-t_0)\frac{\partial f}{\partial t}(t_0,y_0) + (y-y_0)\frac{\partial f}{\partial y}(t_0,y_0)\right] \\ &+ \left[\frac{(t-t_0)^2}{2}\frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial t^2}(t_0,y_0) + (t-t_0)(y-y_0)\frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial t \partial y}(t_0,y_0) + \frac{(y-y_0)^2}{2}\frac{\partial^2 f}{\partial y^2}(t_0,y_0)\right] \\ &+ \cdots + \left[\frac{1}{n!}\sum_{j=0}^{n}\binom{n}{j}(t-t_0)^{n-j}(y-y_0)^j\frac{\partial^n f}{\partial t^{n-j}\partial y^j}(t_0,y_0)\right] \end{aligned}$$

and

$$R_n(t,y) = \frac{1}{(n+1)!}\sum_{j=0}^{n+1}\binom{n+1}{j}(t-t_0)^{n+1-j}(y-y_0)^j\frac{\partial^{n+1} f}{\partial t^{n+1-j}\partial y^j}(\xi,\mu).$$

$n = 2$:

$$f(t+\Delta t, y+\Delta y) = f(t,y) + f_t\Delta t + f_y\Delta y + \frac{1}{2}\left[f_{tt}(\Delta t)^2 + 2f_{ty}\Delta t\Delta y + f_{yy}(\Delta y)^2\right] + \ldots$$

$$R_2(t,y) = \frac{1}{6}\left[(\Delta t)^3 f_{ttt} + 3(\Delta t)^2\Delta y f_{tty} + 3\Delta t(\Delta y)^2 f_{tyy} + (\Delta y)^3 f_{yyy}\right](\xi,\mu).$$

$n = 3$:

$$\begin{aligned} f(t+\Delta t, y+\Delta y) = f(t,y) &+ f_t\Delta t + f_y\Delta y + \frac{1}{2}\left[f_{tt}(\Delta t)^2 + 2f_{ty}\Delta t\Delta y + f_{yy}(\Delta y)^2\right] \\ &+ \frac{1}{6}\left[(\Delta t)^3 f_{ttt} + 3(\Delta t)^2\Delta y f_{tty} + 3\Delta t(\Delta y)^2 f_{tyy} + (\Delta y)^3 f_{yyy}\right] + \ldots \end{aligned}$$

$$R_3(t,y) = \frac{1}{24}\left[(\Delta t)^4 f_{tttt} + 4(\Delta t)^3\Delta y f_{ttty} + 6(\Delta t)^2(\Delta y)^2 f_{ttyy} + 4(\Delta y)^3 f_{tyyy} + (\Delta y)^4 f_{yyyy}\right](\xi,\mu).$$